The Subtle Art of Breathing

By Asha Bandele

in the middle of everything i'm not doing my doorbell rings it's the landlady's lost son i point him up the stairs mildly annoyed to have been interrupted from my intent viewing of a soap opera one life to live ironic now that i think about it.

nobody ever suspects women like me poets politically conscious watch soap operas but we do at least I do grateful to retreat into the fictitious chaos of somebody else's life

but this is not a poem about soap operas

INTRODUCTION

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It's just that I cannot find another way to begin I mean how would you do it?

would you start with a father's scream lancing the air with the little sister's indelicate weep
or the acidic gurgle of a stomach self-destruction
maybe you would simply begin like a broadcast journalist scanning a teleprompter:
in anchorage today a 30 year old black woman was found in her apartment dead of an overdose. The incident has been ruled a suicide . . .

but this is not a poem about how to begin a poem
or a poem about lost sons and landlady's
this is not a poem about soap operas
in islam they say from Allah we come to Allah we return
leaving the curious among us hungry
for the story in between arrival and
departure the person in the center the thin arms
desperate

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to stop the steady crush of closing walls her first
wall was daughter
her second was wife not much room there to just be a
woman
holy or unholy
but this is not a poem about religion

there are people who have accused me of creating the
various & sundry crises in my life
there are people who have accused me of refusing joy &
of blanketing the sun but then there are people who
know as I know that even as we laugh we cannot ignore
the wincing in our eyes
we are not crazy or invested in sadness
sister was it that you knew there was no space
to be second best or needy in a country swallowing up
the earth from the inside out they incinerate their
own children here
i have seen the scraping
their own 8 year olds into garbage bags or compactors

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whatever's efficient &

it might be that this is a political poem

forgive me
i feel guilty borrowing your family's pain you were not
my daughter
not my sister i never even met you your name &
troubles were a footnote at the end of a discussion on
lovers and where to go for dinner that night i know
this space of mourning is not mine to occupy but i cannot
leave your life reads like the details of my life & i
must know why you are dead I am not yet we both
were 30
black female & fighting histories of drugs violence
separation loss
start stop start stop again
We are a ritual of everyday blackwoman experience
stories repeated on sally & Geraldo ricki lake & the news
Nothing unusual

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been there done that &

maybe this is a poem about déjà vu or a poem about
phyllis hyman or billie holiday maybe this is a poem about
my grandmother or your best friend from back in the
day maybe this is a poem about you but it is
definitely not a poem about invented crises
fictitious lives or retreating pretending
lying turning away or even praying

this is not a poem about soap operas.

Once i was told that i was more than all of my hurting
added up together
if i had known you i would have told you that too
girl there was more to you than your violent marriage
more than the brown girl you became crouching
beneath the dining room table more to you than the
baby you lost or the last time you or any one of gave
ourselves up

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Like unwilling virgins to cocaine vodka tonics cheap
wine newports colombian gold & beer when the money
got tight girl there was clear skin beneath your
bruises muscle behind the split ribs a raving beauty
beyond his broke up sight & screams
& did you ever see here even
once & if i did & if i told you we were the same woman
sisters maybe twins would you have been able to hear
me

was this the first time you felt powerful? did you feel
finally some control did you say to yourself can't be
yanked out from under this table gotta hiding place that
[he] won't never find me in did you think at last a
truth no one will ignore that the world will believe you
now i just remember feeling very calm

as i slid into pieces of the splintered wood of my
dormroom floor all those years ago you know what would
have happened if you had survived been surprised by

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somebody coming back in after the 18th pill? you would have tried to fight them as they tried to make you walk they would have dragged you up & down the floors til the ambulance arrived someone would have slapped you to keep you awake whoever found you might have read your journals displayed your diaries said they just wanted to understand at the hospital if you arrived conscious they would have made you eat a black chalk substance to induce vomiting you would have vomited uncontrollably in front of you they would have stirred through it picking out the pills for analysis there is no other way to say this besides i told you

this is not a poem about soap operas but

this may be a poem that warns breathing is a difficult and subtle art
it may be a poem to say simply i understand sister after 3 attempts
years past the last one i understand girl

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i think this is a poem that wants to assert itself
i'm proud even glad that i'm a survivor &
sometimes when i am quiet & sometimes when i am alone & sometimes when i am reflective & sometimes when i am scared & sometimes
sometimes when i am watching soap operas i say oneday i'm gonna be even more than a survivor i'll be a celebrant inside myself
party girl in my own soul i'll take myself out to fancy restaurants
bring
me roses then make love to myself & in the heat of passion call out
my
own name (asha, asha . . .) yes i'm gonna marry myself
does that sound crazy?

martin luther king said *we may not get there together but we as a people . . .*
& What if i do girl? Get there & find myself dancing wild

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in a bright silver dress &

high heeled shoes will you come too ok not

now

but your next time around be your own sensual dance

partner in

high heeled shoes fine as hell girl & so so so fulla

life

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AWARD HISTORY

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